

LOGIC OF CONCORD WITH COLLECTIVES IN BIBLICAL NARRATIVE*

E. J. REVELL

UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

1. Introduction.

1.1 For the purposes of this study, collectives are defined as nouns which are morphologically singular, but which may have singular or plural coreferents.¹ A coreferent of a collective is commonly described as showing “grammatical” concord when singular, “notional” concord (*constructio ad sensum*) when plural.² If this is taken as indicating that concord is determined either by linguistic convention (a noun which is singular in form has singular coreferents) or by the speaker’s perception of reality (the plural is used to make reference to a collection of individuals), a difficulty appears. A compound subject should have plural coreferents both according to grammatical convention, and as a reflection of reality, yet a compound subject of which the first component designates

* Article originally received October, 1992.

¹“Coreferents” are morphs which have the same referent as does the collective. In Hebrew, these are pronominal (including the pronominal morph in a verb form, which represents the subject), or nominal attributives (adjectives or participles). Other possibilities, such as nouns in apposition, are disregarded here. Cases in which the conditioning of concord is not certainly based on a collective (as in coreferents of compounds, or of construct phrases which include singular or plural nouns), are not included.

²C. Brockelmann, *Hebräische Syntax* (Neukirchen: Neukirchener, 1956): §28.b f; B. K. Waltke and M. O’Connor, *An Introduction to Biblical Hebrew Syntax* (Winona Lake: Eisenbrauns, 1990): §§6.6, 14.2c; R. Quirk, et al., *A Comprehensive Grammar of the English Language* (London: Longman, 1985): §10.35.

an individual is most commonly treated as singular.³ If the system is "illogical" in this matter, can logic be assumed elsewhere?

1.2 There is regularity in the choice of number in the coreferents of collectives in one limited area. An attributive which presents a quality of the group designated by the collective (and not of the individuals which form it) is singular.⁴ As described, the basis of this is semantic, so the value of the term "grammatical" for such concord is questionable. Equally, one would expect that a speaker would be led to think of a group performing particular actions as a number of individuals rather than as a unit, and so to the "notional" use of a plural verb where the subject was a collective. It is true that an active verb with a collective subject is often plural, but there is no group of verbs which are characteristically plural when the subject is collective. This might be held to show that the "notional" plural is a free variant of the "grammatical" singular, were it not that the use of the latter is, in one area at least, clearly conditioned.

1.3 This paper is an attempt to determine what the terms "grammatical" and "notional" represent when used in the way indicated. It is based on the books of Judges, Samuel, and Kings, but is limited to collectives which denote humans. This corpus provides some 400 cases in which a collective is subject of a verb, or is modified by an attributive, and so is marked for number, a sample large enough to provide a satisfactory basis for conclusions. The language of these books is homogeneous, and can reasonably be treated synchronically.⁵ The method of study is

³M. Moreshet ("The Predicate Preceding a Compound Subject in the Biblical Language," *L'šonenu* 31 [1967]: 253) states that about 85% of such compounds are treated as singular in biblical prose overall. The choice of number in a verb with a compound subject in the corpus is conditioned semantically, as is suggested here for collectives, as is shown in E. J. Revell ("Concord with Compound Subjects and Related Use of Pronouns," *VT* 43 [1993]: 69–87).

⁴See E. Qimron, *The Hebrew of the Dead Sea Scrolls* (Atlanta: Scholars, 1986): 83 n. 60, and the comment on examples (1, 1a) in Quirk (N 2): §10.36. For the usage of the corpus, see §6 below.

⁵The corpus is made up of historical narrative of various types (the poetic passages, Judges 5, 1 Sam 2:1–10, 2 Sam 1:17–27, and 22:1–23:7 are excluded). Since the approach is synchronic, the possibility that the corpus was composed from material from different sources is irrelevant; the language is homogeneous, so it can be assumed that the "narrator" responsible for the present form of the text removed features of his sources which conflicted with his usage. The relationship of the received text to some earlier text form is equally irrelevant, although it is recognized that any particular peculiarity may be due to some accident of compilation or transmission of the text, or to the factors which cause variation

simple description: an attempt to find significant correlations between usage and context. The paper concludes that such correlation is evident. The choice of number in the coreferents of collectives is conditioned; it provides part of the expressive content of the text. Some sociolinguistic studies, which deal with similar topics in other languages, have been used to support the conclusions presented.⁶

2. Number and Transitivity.

2.1 When compared in terms of the number of the verb of which they are subject, the collectives denoting humans found in the corpus⁷ fall naturally into three groups in terms of the number of their coreferents.

1. The name Israel, and the names of the constituent tribes (and similar groups), are treated as plural in only two of the 45 possible cases (4%).

2. The majority of collectives, such as *איש*, 'man', *העם*, 'the people', gentilics, such as *הכנעני*, 'the Canaanite', names such as *אדם*, *אדם*, 'Edom, Aram', and so on, are treated as plural in a range centered on 40%. The lowest, gentilic designations, are plural in 3 of 9 cases (33%), the highest, the collective 'man' with a numerical modifier, in 8 of 17 cases (47%).

3. Members of groups (1) and (2) preceded by *כל* 'all' are treated as plural in more than 60% of the cases. (*כל ישראל* 'all Israel' 18 of 29, or 63%; *כל העם* 'all the people' 14 of 19, or 74%.)⁸

in spoken language. No serious attempt has been made to identify these, since the usage which this paper sets out to describe should form part of the basis for such identification.

⁶The only attempt I am aware of to describe the basis of numerical concord with collectives in a limited corpus, G. Nixon ("Corporate-Concord Phenomena in English," *Studia Neophilologica* 44 [1972]: 120-126), is restricted to formal description. U. Fries ("Zur Kongruenz bei Kollektiven," in *Europäische Mehrsprachigkeit: Festschrift zum 70. Geburtstag von Mario Wandruszka* [ed. Wolfgang Pöckl; Tübingen: Niemeyer, 1981]: 24), suggests that English usage is at least to some extent sociolinguistically conditioned, as is suggested here for Biblical Hebrew. The survey in P. Mühlhäusler and R. Harré (*Pronouns and People: The Linguistic Construction of Social and Personal Identity* [Oxford: Blackwell, 1990]: 72) of the possible functions of "unnatural" concord in German suggests that these are similar to those seen here for the choice of number in the coreferents of collectives.

⁷The term "collective" is henceforward used in this restricted sense.

⁸This is probably related to the fact that a collective subject is more likely to be treated as plural if more clearly defined (as by the definite article or descriptive modifiers), a counterpart of the significance of the "highly individuated object" (see P. J. Hopper and S. A. Thompson, "Transitivity in Grammar and Discourse," *Language* 56 [1980]: 252 [J]).

2.2 The names in group (1) represent not only population groups, but also their eponymous ancestors. The groups themselves are often designated as the descendants (בְּנֵי) of these ancestors, as בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל 'the descendants of Israel', etc. The existence of plural designations equivalent to these collectives is no doubt the reason why the latter are usually treated as singular.⁹ Equivalent collective and plural designations of this sort do not appear to be free variants. The collective forms act as subject of a clause in less than 10% of their occurrences, the equivalent plurals in 50% or more. For instance בְּנֵימִין 'Benjamin' as a collective, acts as subject in the corpus in 4 of 48 possible cases (8%), בְּנֵי בְּנֵימִין 'the descendants of Benjamin' in 12 of 22 cases (55%). There is, then, a relationship between the representation of a group as "actor" (subject) and the choice of plural number.

2.3 This tendency to treat a group as plural where it appears as "actor" is related to the transitivity of the clause. Verbs can be classified in four groups: (1) passive, stative, or reflexive verbs, (2) verbs of motion, (3) verbs of speech or perception, (4) other active verbs. Where Benjamin, Judah, or Israel, is the subject, the verb falls into group (1) in 10 of 40 cases (25%). Where one of the plural equivalents, 'descendants of Benjamin', etc., is subject, the verb falls into group (1) in 10 of 72 cases (14%). Six of these ten (*Nip'al* of אָסַף, or *Hitpa'el* or equivalent of קָבַץ or פָּקַד, Judg 10:17; 20:14,15; 1 Sam 7:7; 2 Sam 2:25; 1 Kgs 20:27) could be seen as having active meanings, as 'assemble' rather than passive, as 'be gathered'. In two other cases the verb forms part of a phrase with active implications: אָבָה לִשְׁמָע "be willing to hear" (Judg 20:13 *qere*) and יָכַל לְהַהָרִים "be able to destroy" (1 Kgs 9:21). The remaining two cases are forms of the *Nip'al* of נָהַם, "to be sorry for" (Judg 21:6), and the verb הָיָה 'to be' with a numeral as complement (1 Sam 11:8).

2.4 The use of הָיָה with a plural subject in 1 Sam 11:8 has a parallel with the collective subject treated as singular in 2 Sam 24:9.¹⁰ Otherwise,

⁹Unfortunately for this study, this aspect of such pairs is not considered in D. I. Block ("Israel"—'sons of Israel': A Study in Hebrew eponymic usage," *Studies in Religion/Sciences Religieuses* 13 [1984]: 301–326) or in the former work cited there. If Block's historical conclusion (pp. 321–322) is correct, these pairs provide another example of the use of variant forms with distinct functions during the period in which one is replacing the other. Cf. §9.5.

¹⁰The verb is feminine here. Names of population groups are occasionally treated as feminine elsewhere, both in the corpus and outside it (see A. B. Davidson, *Hebrew Syntax* [3rd ed.; Edinburgh: Clark, 1901]: §116 rem. 5; also Yohanan Aharoni, *Arad*

the verbs with collective subjects are “be repulsive” (באש *Nip'al*, 1 Sam 13:4), “be terrified” (בהל *Nip'al*, Judg 20:41), “be weak” (דלל Judg 6:6), “become a byword” (היה למשל 1 Kgs 9:7), “be strong” (חזק Judg 1:28), “be defeated” (נגף *Nip'al*, 1 Sam 4:2,10; 2 Kgs 14:12) and “glorify oneself” (פאר *Hitpa'el*, Judg 7:2). Of the two possibilities, the collective treated as singular is clearly preferred as subject for verbs at the low end of the scale of transitivity.

2.5 The case at the other end of the scale is less clear. The phrase ‘descendants of Benjamin/Judah/Israel’ is subject of an active verb which cannot be classed as one of motion, speech, or perception in 22 of 72 cases (30%—the verb “to fight” in Judg 1:8 is included).¹¹ Benjamin or Judah is subject of such a verb in 2 of 16 cases (13%). The proportion for Israel, 10 of 25 cases, is much higher (40%). Five of these cases occur in Judg 11:13–21, in the negotiation between Jephthah and the King of Bene Ammon, a passage which is clearly exceptional in this feature (see §9.4). If this passage is ignored, Israel is subject of a verb of this sort in 5 of 17 cases (29%), and for the group as a whole the figure is 7 of 33 cases, or 21%.

3. Number and “Narrative Prominence.”

3.1 Clauses with collective subject show a similar correlation of transitivity with plural number. Where a verb or participle acting as predicate is passive, stative or reflexive, it is nearly always singular where the subject is collective. Where the predicate indicates motion, the singular is less common. Where it indicates speech or perception, the predicate is often plural. This can be illustrated by a survey of the roots most commonly used in each group to head predicates with collective subjects. The numbers show the number of plural verbs out of the total used with a collective subject.

Inscriptions [Jerusalem: Israel Exploration Society, 1981]: Arad letter #24 1.20). The groups concerned in the corpus are all treated both as masculine singular and as masculine plural as well. The use of the feminine is too rare to allow the suggestion of any function in synchronic terms. Coreferents of feminine collectives are usually masculine, even that of נערה “girl” in the second main clause in Judg 21:12. Such gender shifts are ignored here. Only number is considered.

¹¹The form is *Nip'al*, probably with original reciprocal value in this verb. The opponent fought with is never presented as a direct object. Nevertheless, one of the two parties is subject, not both, so it is difficult to avoid seeing the other (the opponent) as recipient of the action.

Passive, etc.			Motion			Speech, etc.		Other active
היה	be	3/15	בוא	arrive	5/15	אמר	say	9/16 לקח take 3/7
קצץ/ז	be called	1/6	הלך	walk	7/15	ראה	see	4/8 עשה do 5/7
חזק	be strong	0/4	יצא	go out	2/12	שמע	hear	5/8 שלח send 2/5
נגף	be struck	1/4	נוס	flee	4/12	ידע	know	3/6 שים place 2/4

As with the survey in §2.5, the numbers in the “other active” column do not show the expected progression. Again, this is partly due to the exceptional character of Judg 11:13–21. If this passage were excluded, the figures for ‘take’ would be 2/5, those for ‘send’ 2/3: more in line with expectations. It is a fact, however, that collectives—or even plural nominals denoting groups of humans—are not often used with verbs of this group. If the reason were understood, we might also understand why the proportion of singular verbs with collective subjects is unexpectedly high in this group.

3.2 The correlation between high transitivity and the treatment of a collective as plural can be investigated more precisely in terms of the parameters of transitivity set up in P. J. Hopper and S. A. Thompson.¹² Such an investigation is, however, confronted with several problems. The limits of our knowledge of Biblical Hebrew would reduce treatment of parameters like “aspect” and “punctuality” largely to guesswork. In addition, the boundaries of semantic categories are typically ill-defined. Some examples are easy to assign to opposing categories, but for a considerable proportion, assignment can only be arbitrary, as would be the case if all humans were to be categorized as “tall” or “short.” Moreover, a variety of factors typically condition the choice between contrasting items which carry a semantic load, just as a number of factors, such as sex and diet, would affect human stature. It is easy enough to select examples to show that a particular factor is significant in some cases, but the conclusion that it is significant in all cases must be derived by argument. It cannot be demonstrated, because no one factor is always dominant.

¹²Hopper and Thompson (N 8).

3.3 According to Hopper and Thompson's study,¹³ a clause with only one participant is low in transitivity. Since low transitivity correlates with use of the singular, such a clause is likely to have a singular verb, as in

1 Sam 4:10 וינגף ישראל
Israel was driven back.

1 Kgs 18:24 ויען כל העם
All the people answered.

A clause with more than one participant, and so with higher transitivity, is likely to have a plural verb, as

2 Sam 18:7 וינגפו שם עם ישראל לפני עבדי דוד
Israel was there driven back before David's servants.

1 Kgs 18:21 וְלֹא עָנוּ הָעָם אֹתוֹ דָּבָר

According to Hopper and Thompson,¹⁴ a negative clause is lower in transitivity than an affirmative one. The verb of a negative clause with a collective subject is regularly singular in the corpus, even where the subject is given prominence, as

והעם לא ידע כי הלך יונתן
1 Sam 14:3
The people did not know that Jonathan had gone.

The clause quoted from 1 Kgs 18:21 presents an exception. This may be because the number of participants gives it a high level of transitivity, but the evidence of the corpus is too limited to demonstrate this. There are too many variables for a detailed illustration of the correlation between plurality and transitivity through Hopper and Thompson's parameters to carry much weight. A general correlation between a high level of transitivity and the use of the plural is as much as can be established.

3.4 The use of the plural appears to be characteristic of clauses which are prominent in terms of narrative function. In some cases prominence

¹³Ibid., 252 (A).

¹⁴*Ibid.*, 252 (F).

is marked through syntactic structure.¹⁵ In other cases it can only be inferred from the part played in the story by the referent of the structure. The clause quoted from 1 Kgs 18:21 shows the people as unresponsive to Elijah's appeal, and so heightens suspense by suggesting that he may fail to win them over. Narrative prominence is related to "grounding," and so to the level of transitivity,¹⁶ although the nature of the relationship is uncertain.¹⁷ However, a prominent structure can occur in any clause, whether foregrounded or backgrounded.¹⁸ The significance of "narrative prominence" is, then, more local than that envisaged for "grounding" as currently understood in Biblical Hebrew.¹⁹ Like the level of transitivity, narrative prominence is a somewhat indistinct concept, but it can more easily be related to objective criteria. Narrative prominence is, then, the main concern of this study.

¹⁵Various terms, such as "theme, topic, focus" may be used to describe an item given prominence in this way, but I am unwilling to use them before some suitable comprehensive study has defined them in terms of Hebrew usage. Beginnings have been made, as in L. Lode, "Postverbal Word Order in Biblical Hebrew," *Semitics* 9 (1984): section #3, and C. J. H. van der Merwe, *The Old Hebrew Particle gam* (Arbeiten zu Text und Sprache im alten Testament 34; St. Ottilien: EOS, 1990): chapter 3.

¹⁶Hopper and Thompson (N 8): 280–294.

¹⁷See R. Fasold, *The Sociolinguistics of Language* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1990): 82.

¹⁸Clauses without finite verbs are always backgrounded. Items in such clauses are quite often given prominence, as described in E. J. Revell, "The Conditioning of Word Order in Verbless Clauses in Biblical Hebrew," *JSS* 34 (1989): 1–24.

¹⁹Cf. the idea of "local background" used in S. A. Thompson, "Grammar and Discourse: The English Detached Participial Clause," in *Discourse Perspectives on Syntax* (ed. Flora Klein-Andreu; New York: Academic, 1983): 44–45. The view of "grounding" in biblical narrative referred to is that of R. E. Longacre (*Joseph* [Winona Lake: Eisenbrauns, 1989]: chapter 3, schematized on p. 81), where a close correlation between grounding and the type of clause used to present the material is envisaged. While generally valid, this probably needs modification. See Longacre's own questions on perfect verbs (*ibid.*, 82, n. 6) and on negative clauses (*idem.*, "The Discourse Structure of the Flood Narrative," *JAAR* 47, Supplement B [1979]: 97). A negated clause does appear to carry forward the action of the narrative in Judg 8:20 as in 1 Kgs 18:21. A "background format" clause in 1 Kgs 20:1, and one of "foreground format" in 2 Kgs 6:24, present virtually the same information, which has specific relevance for the following narrative in the first case, only general relevance in the second. Temporal sequence is characteristic of "foreground," but the foreground clause beginning 1 Kgs 18:30 moves the action to a point earlier than the "time of the Minḥah" of the previous verse, see v. 36. A "foreground format" clause can continue a relative clause (background) as in 1 Kgs 21:4. It seems probable that "grounding" is a highly complex phenomenon, of which "narrative prominence" may be an aspect, but that cannot be argued here.

4. Verbs (i) Singular and Plural where the Subject is Preposed.

4.1 Position before the verb of a clause always gives a constituent some prominence, marking it as the “topic” of the clause, or as the “focus” of the narrator’s interest. Clauses in which a collective subject is placed before the verb can, then, provide a suitable test of the possibility that there is a relationship between the treatment of a collective as plural and its prominence in the narrative.²⁰ Overall (omitting questionable cases), a verb with a preceding collective subject is singular in 17 cases in the corpus, plural in 32. All these cases are treated in §§4.2–4.7.

4.2 A verb following a collective subject is singular where the collective is placed before the verb on account of its intrinsic significance, not on account of its relationship to other items in the context. This occurs where it represents the new information in the answer to a question in

Judg 1:2	יהודה יעלה
Judah will go up.	

Another case in direct speech terminates a speech of prediction, in 2 Sam 17:3 (יהיה). The passage is obscure, but the clause appears to give the result of what precedes; it does not contrast with it. Examples occur in narrative where the collective occurs in one of a set of parallel examples which complement each other rather than contrasting, as

Judg 1:29	ואפרים לא הוריש . . .
Ephraim did not drive out . . .	

also (with the same verb) in Judg 1:30,31,33.²¹

4.3 The verb is also singular where the clause repeats information given before, to provide background for what follows, as

Judg 20:39	ובנימין החל להכות חללים . . .
Benjamin began to cause casualties . . .	

²⁰Clauses with participial predicates are not included here, as in these, the subject stands in first place in the unmarked order. See Waltke and O’Connor (N 2): §8.4.2e. On the function of the P-S order, see Revell, “Conditioning” (N 18).

²¹Possibly also the examples with יפנה in 1 Sam 13:17,18, but the subject, ראש “division,” is not found with plural coreferents, and may not be properly regarded as a collective. The use of ראש as subject of a singular verb in Judg 9:37, which would also fit this category (as complementary, not contrastive), is similarly ignored.

forest where honey was plentiful sets the scene for Jonathan's accidental sin (but the text is widely distrusted here). In 1 Sam 14:41 (יִצְאוֹ) the innocence of the people establishes the fact that either Saul or Jonathan is guilty. In 2 Sam 2:10 (הָיוּ), the fact of Judah's following David provides the motivation for the battle in the following chapter. In 2 Sam 4:1 (וַנְּבַהֲלוּ) the terror of Israel provides motivation for their going over to David. In 2 Kgs 25:5 (וַנִּפְצֹוּ) the scattering of the king's force explains his uncontested capture. In a few cases a clause of this sort has no specific significance for what follows, but seems to present a particularly striking feature of the situation, as in 1 Sam 13:7 (חָרְדוּ), 2 Sam 15:30 (חָפְּזוּ), 23:10 (יִשְׁכְּבוּ). This is presumably true of the case in 1 Sam 2:33 (יָמוּתוּ), but the context is obscure.

Other constituents preceding the verb.

4.8 Other constituents are occasionally placed before the verb of a clause with a collective subject. Where a direct object marked by the preposition *את* is so placed, the verb is singular, as in 1 Sam 7:14 (הִצִּיל). The clause continues the preceding topic (note the anaphoric pronoun). The verb is plural in 2 Kgs 25:10 (נִתְּצוּ), where the object introduces a new topic. An adverbial is placed before the singular verb of a clause in Judg 11:16 (הֵלֵךְ), 2 Sam 1:4 (נִפְּלָה), 2:27 (נִעְלָה), 1 Kgs 12:1 (בָּא), 2 Kgs 8:20 (פָּשַׁע). Where the adverbial refers to a participant, the clause is incidental. It has no significance for the ongoing narrative in 2 Kgs 8:20. In Judg 11:16, it occurs in a passage of historical synopsis in which singular coreferents are unusually common (but see §7.3). Where the adverbial refers to an individual participant, the verb is plural, as

1 Kgs 2:15 וְעָלִי שְׁמוֹ כָּל יִשְׂרָאֵל פְּנִיהֶם לְמִלְכָּךְ
All Israel looked to me to rule.

Here the adverbial refers to the speaker, and the importance of the clause to him (it is a claim for status) appears to be reflected by the choice of the plural verb (cf. §9.3). In 2 Sam 15:11 (הֵלְכוּ), where a plural verb also follows an adverbial, the 200 unsuspecting men who "accompanied" Absalom must represent, at the very least, a significant depletion of the forces available to David in Jerusalem, explaining the fact that he had no resource but flight (2 Sam 15:14), even if their ignorance of the intended rebellion might make them a doubtful asset to Absalom. This is, then, an incidental clause of considerable interest for the narrative.

4.9 Grammatical features cannot account for the distribution of singular and plural in these verbs which follow a collective subject. As described, the choice of number does correlate with the relative significance of the structure for the narrative—its relative prominence. “Narrative prominence” can also account for the choice of number in the few cases where a constituent other than the subject precedes a verb with a collective subject. The interpretation of “prominence” is, of course, often subjective, but the regularity of the pattern shown where the criterion—whether the structure contrasts with what precedes or no—approaches objectivity is a significant support for the view presented here.

5. Verbs (ii) Number Variation in the Same Lexical Context.

5.1 The effects of narrative prominence in other situations can be observed through comparison of clauses with the same verb and the same collective subject. (There are no examples of the same collective subject used with singular and plural forms of the same participle heading the predicate. Examples with similar subjects are given.) Some dozen groups of clauses related in this way can be found, of which the following are typical examples. All examples of the verbs or participles used with the collective subject in question are discussed.

5.2 **אִישׁ יִשְׂרָאֵל**, **הָעָם**, ‘The people, the men of Israel’; **אָמַר** ‘Say’. Where a singular verb with ‘the people’ as subject introduces a direct quotation, the content of the speech is of minor significance to the narrative. In 1 Sam 10:11, the speech is a casual comment.²⁴ In 1 Sam 14:45, it opposes Saul’s decision (given in the preceding verse) to kill Jonathan, but this is secondary to the following clause (in which “the people” is repeated as subject) which presents the result of this successful opposition. The situation is similar in 2 Sam 18:3. Where “the people” is subject of a plural verb presenting a direct quotation in 1 Sam 14:40, the speech conveys the people’s assent to the carrying out of the investigation which led to Saul’s decision to kill Jonathan. This presents dramatic irony. The reader knows that Saul’s misguided enthusiasm has made Jonathan technically guilty. The same distinction between the use of a singular verb to introduce unimportant material, and a plural verb where what is said is more significant, can be seen where the speech is not

²⁴It is evidently related as the origin of a “proverbial” saying, but this saying has no particular significance in its immediate context. See the discussion in P. Kyle McCarter, *I Samuel* (Anchor Bible 8; Garden City: Doubleday, 1980): 183.

quoted directly. In 1 Sam 17:27 "The people told (singular) him the same sort of thing" shows that David's second enquiry elicited the same information as the first (given in 1 Sam 17:25). In 1 Sam 30:6 "The people said (plural) to stone him" has a much more prominent role in the narrative. It indicates the state of mind of David's men, showing that events have placed him in a very dangerous situation.

5.3 In 1 Sam 17:25 "The men of Israel said" (singular) introduces the quotation of casual gossip.²⁵ It is true that this catches David's attention, but it leads only indirectly to his confrontation with Goliath (cf. 1 Sam 17:31). In Judg 8:22, where "the men of Israel" is subject and the verb "say" is plural, it introduces the invitation to Gideon to become king. This would be widely regarded as an impious assault on the foundations of society (cf. the dismay later evoked by a similar request in 1 Sam 8:6–9). It is naturally prominent.

5.4 כל העם, 'All the people'; הלך 'walk, go'. In 2 Sam 6:19, "All the people went (s.), each to his home" closes the description of the bringing of the ark to Jerusalem. "The people" play no significant role in the context. In 1 Sam 11:15 "All the people went (pl.) to Gilgal" introduces the story of the acclamation of Saul as king. "All the people" play a central role; they are represented by the 3 m.pl. subject pronouns in the two following clauses. In Judg 7:7 "All the people will go, each to his place," where the subject precedes the verb, the use of the plural is due to the contrast with what precedes (see §4.5).

5.5 The use of the plural in 2 Sam 3:1 ובית שאול הלכים ודלים "The house of Saul went on (pl.) getting weaker," contrasts with the use of the singular in 2 Sam 15:12 והעם הולך ורב את אבשלום "The people with Absalom went on (s.) increasing in number." The significance of the information for the narrative is about the same in the two passages. In 2 Sam 15:12, the clause does not contrast with the preceding, it complements it. Moreover, it ends a section of narrative. For these reasons the clause in 2 Sam 15:12 is relatively low in prominence. The clause

²⁵The ancient versions take איש ישראל as denoting "a man of Israel" here. However such a designation is typically used only where distinction from foreigners is required, as in Judg 7:14, also Num 25:8,14; otherwise, the epithet "of Israel" is superfluous. Collective value is more likely. See the comment in H. W. Hertzberg, *Die Samuelbücher* (2nd ed.; Das Alte Testament Deutsch 10; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1960): 114 n. 4. McCarter ([N 24]: 299) takes the phrase as a vocative, but offers no support for the view. As far as I know, there is no parallel.

in 2 Sam 3:1 does contrast with the preceding clause.²⁶ The use of the plural verb is no doubt mainly due to this contrast. The clause stands at the beginning of a section dealing with the fortunes of Saul's house, which continues, after a digression, in 2 Sam 3:6.

5.6 כל העם 'All the people'; עמד 'Stand (still)'. In 2 Sam 20:12 "All the people stopped (s.)" the information is new, but is secondary in comparison with the following clauses, which describe the remedy for the situation. For this reason the clause has low prominence. In 2 Sam 2:28 "All the people stopped (pl.)" marks the end of a fierce battle. Its significance for the narrative is indicated by the two following complementary clauses with subject coreferent with "all the people": "They pursued Israel no further and they did not continue to fight." The full meaning of "All the people stood (s.) in the covenant" (2 Kgs 23:3) is uncertain. The clause ends the description of a ceremony performed by the king as representative of the community, and presumably conveys the people's assent to his undertakings on their behalf ("the people" plays no other part in the context). It is thus secondary to his actions, as well as terminal, and so low in prominence.

5.7 In 1 Kgs 22:19 "The whole host of heaven was standing (singular participle), beside him" is a descriptive clause, which complements the preceding. It presents part of the background of a narrative within the narrative: a vision used by a prophet to convey a warning. In 1 Sam 17:3 "Israel were standing (plural participle) on the hill on the other side" the use of the plural participle is no doubt mainly due to the fact that this clause contrasts with the preceding. The clause presents part of the background to the mainline narrative.

5.8 Grammatical features cannot account for the choice of singular or plural verbs in these examples. Equally, it is impossible to argue that the collective was perceived as denoting a single group when the verb is singular, a collection of individuals when the verb is plural, without supporting the argument by reference to the situation in which the clause stands. The use of the plural in these examples corresponds generally to the categories set up in §4, so that a preliminary description of narrative prominence can be set up.

²⁶The participles in that clause, הלך וחזק "became progressively stronger," are singular, but the subject, David, is technically an example of synecdoche, not a collective.

Prominent:

1. Material which contrasts with what precedes: §§4.5, 5.4 (Judg 7:7), 5.5 (2 Sam 3:1), 5.7 (1 Sam 17:3).

2. Material which is not thematic, but which is significant for the progress of the narrative: §§4.6, 7, also the "significant" speech in §§5.2, 3.

3. Material at the beginning of, or within, a narrative section dealing with a topic which is mentioned several times, and so can be considered a theme: §§5.4 (1 Sam 11:15), 5.5 (2 Sam 3:1), 5.6 (2 Sam 2:28).

Non-prominent:

4. Material which complements what precedes: §§4.2, 5.5 (2 Sam 15:12), 5.7 (1 Kgs 22:19).

5. Material which is not significant for the progress of the narrative because it is (explicitly or implicitly) repeated, and serves only as the context for other events, or because it merely adds descriptive detail to what precedes: §§4.3, 4.4, 5.6 (2 Sam 20:12), 5.7 (1 Kgs 22:19).

6. Material terminating a section of narrative, or occurring within it, but neither thematic, nor otherwise significant for its progress: §§5.4 (2 Sam 6:19), 5.5 (2 Sam 15:12), 5.6 (2 Kgs 23:3), also the unimportant speech in §§5.2, 3.

5.9 The survey of number in verbs with collective subjects in sections §4 and §5 demonstrates a strong correlation between the use of the plural and high prominence in terms of narrative function. Overall, the head of the predicate is singular in about 60% of the cases where the subject is collective. Singular can, then, be considered the "unmarked" or "default" usage, the form chosen where there is no need to draw special attention to the clause. Plural, the "marked" usage, carries the information that the collective subject, or the clause as a whole, is of particular significance in the narrative. It is a means of drawing attention to the structure comparable to the use of louder or slower enunciation, or to underlining in a written text.

6. Attributives.

6.1 An adjective or participle attributive to a collective typically presents a quality or characteristic of the group represented by the collective, or of the individuals which form it. Such attributives, and also demonstratives used as attributives, are typically singular, as

1 Kgs 20:13, 28
All this great crowd.

כל ההמון הגדול הזה

Other attributives with stative or passive value used in this way are רב "large" (2 Sam 13:34; 1 Kgs 3:8; 5:21); אחר "other" (Judg 2:10); בתולה "virgin" (Judg 21:12); בטח "secure" (Judg 18:10); שקט ובטח "calm and secure" (Judg 18:27; also Judg 18:7, but the syntax there is obscure).²⁷ Participles of active verbs (with or without a nominal object) which present a characteristic of the group designated by the collective are typically singular in the same way, as

1 Sam 22:18
85 men who wore priestly garments (i.e., 85 priests).

שמנים וחמשה איש נשא אפור בד

So also עשה מלחמה "makers of war" (1 Kgs 12:21), and שלף חרב "sword bearers" (Judg 8:10; 20:2,15,17,46; 2 Sam 24:9; 2 Kgs 3:26).²⁸ The same is true of ישב "inhabitant" followed by a noun or prepositional phrase indicating the place inhabited (Judg 1:9,10,17,21,29; 3:3; 11:21; 2 Sam 5:6; 1 Kgs 9:16). The phrase ישת לבטח (Judg 18:7) could be added, but the syntax of the passage is obscure.²⁹ The singular may also be used where the characteristic presented is of limited duration, as

1 Kgs 20:16
32 kings helping him.³⁰

שלשים ושנים מלך עזר אתו

²⁷ Attributive use of a singular demonstrative occurs in הדור ההוא "that generation" (Judg 2:10), and often with הזה "this." A plural demonstrative occurs in מעט הצאן ההנה "those few sheep" (1 Sam 17:28) where it might well draw attention to the initial quantifier. The same usage (lacking the article) occurs in כל העם אלה "all these people" (1 Sam 2:23, the only use, in the corpus, of a plural demonstrative with a collective denoting humans), but the text is usually felt to be at fault. In אלה הצאן (2 Sam 24:17) the two words are probably in apposition ("These [people], the sheep," so P. Kyle McCarter, *II Samuel* [Anchor Bible 9; Garden City: Doubleday, 1984]: 503), or possibly subject and predicate (so Waltke and O'Connor [N 2]: 295 "These are but sheep"). The demonstrative is not attributive.

²⁸ The same phrase is used as predicate in Judg 20:25 (in the plural), and in Judg 20:35 (in the singular). I can suggest no reason for the variation in number.

²⁹ The plural is used in בקרב הכנעני ישיב הארץ "among the Canaanite, inhabitants of the land" (Judg 1:32,33). This might be due to the influence of the preposition "among," but the following singular coreferent in 1:32 suggests that the plural form may not be original (see §7.2).

³⁰ The participial phrase must have roughly the same value as that of the prepositional phrase in שלשים ושנים מלך עזר אתו "32 kings with him" (1 Kgs 20:1).

the origin which are placed between the verb and the subject: "There set out from there, from the tribe of Dan, from Šor'ah and Eshta'ol, 600 men . . ." In Judg 18:16 the phrase stands in an incidental clause significant for what follows. The size of the force, and its equipment, determines the actions of the main protagonist, the priest. The use of the pronoun in "their weapons" presents the menacing aspect of the force more specifically. The information is presented as new (the article is not used), and so from the viewpoint of the priest, against whom the menace is directed. The use of the plural participle reflects the significance of the phrase in this situation. Judg 18:17 shows the priest standing by while his shrine is plundered. "The 600 men equipped with weapons" (part of the compound subject) are presented as old information (with anaphoric article) as a reminder of the reason for his action. The relatively low prominence is reflected in the use of the singular.

6.4 Another contrasting pair used in the same context occurs in

Judg 9:36 הנה עם יורד מראשי ההרים
Look! people coming down (s.) from the tops of the mountains.

Judg 9:37 הנה עם יורדים מעם טבור הארץ
Look! people coming down (pl.) from near the 'center of the
earth'.

In 9:36, the speaker makes a casual observation on people at such a distance that his companion can reasonably suggest that what he has seen is only shadows on the mountains. The more specific observation in 9:37 is made when the approach of hostile forces can no longer be doubted. The main concerns of the speaker correspond, in direct speech, to the purposes of the narrator in third person narrative (see §9.3). They determine what is marked as prominent or significant. The use of the plural in Judg 9:37 shows that, in contrast to the situation in the preceding verse, the people in question are now a serious concern of the speaker.

6.5 A few other examples also occur. The participles נשאר and נותר “remaining” are used in the singular in 1 Kgs 9:20 and 2 Kgs 25:22, in material extraposed before a clause. The collective modified by the participle is neither the topic of the clause, nor the focus of the narrator’s interest, in either case. The plural is used in 1 Kgs 20:30 in a clause describing the miraculous destruction of those remaining (27,000) from an immense hostile force. The plural is also used in 2 Kgs 25:11 in part of the preposed compound object which is the topic of the last of three

clauses detailing catastrophes. (Their significance is indicated, in the preceding clause, by the use of a plural verb with the collective subject, see §4.8.) In both cases the clause must be considered of considerable significance in its context, and this narrative prominence has presumably induced the use of the plural. The cases of **בְּחֹרֶר** (singular: Judg 20:15,16; plural: 1 Sam 26:2) and **נִמְצָא** (singular: 1 Sam 13:16; plural: 1 Sam 13:15; 2 Kgs 25:19) can be explained in similar ways.

Variation of number in subject and predicate.

6.6 Where a collective with an attributive modifier acts as subject of a clause, the attributive and the head of the predicate may or may not agree in number.³¹ Both are singular in Judg 2:10 (**אֶחָד**), 1 Kgs 12:27 and 2 Kgs 19:30, where the attributive is not an active participle, and the clause is intransitive, or a prediction (see §9.4). Both attributive and verb are plural in Judg 18:16, 1 Sam 14:22 and 2 Sam 15:11. The clause in these cases is sufficiently significant to be marked as prominent by the plural verb. The subject itself is also prominent. It denotes a menace in Judg 18:16 (see §6.3), a significant group of allies in 1 Sam 14:22 (see §6.2), and a similarly significant group in 2 Sam 15:11 (see §4.8). Where the attributive is singular and the head of the predicate plural, the attributive presents a characteristic: “equipped” (**הִגָּדֹר** Judg 18:11); “chosen” (**בְּחֹרֶר** Judg 20:34); “large” (**רַב** 2 Sam 13:34); also the temporary characteristic “going out” (**יָצָא** 1 Sam 17:20). The group designated by these collectives is not significant beyond the function of actor in its immediate context (on Judg 18:11, see §6.3), so that a singular attributive is expected (see §6.1). The verb presents mainline narrative in Judg 18:11 and 20:34. In 1 Sam 17:20, the clause presents a significant incident, consequently the verb is plural (see §4.7). The situation in 2 Sam 13:34 “A large (s.) people travelling (pl.)” is similar. The approach of the group is significant in the narrative context, so the use of the plural is justified (see §5.8.2). In two further cases, the attributive is a demonstrative, and so singular. In Judg 2:20, the collective is thematic, requiring a plural verb (see §5.8.2). On the use of the plural in Judg 2:10, see §4.7.

³¹Variation in the formal marking of number within a structure occurs in other languages (see, e.g., M. M. P. Scherre, “La variation de la règle d’accord du nombre dans le syntagme nominal en Portugais,” in *Variation Omnibus* [ed. D. Sankoff and H. Cedergren; Edmonton: Linguistic Research, 1981]: 125–133), but the reasons are likely to be language-specific.

6.7 The predicate is singular and the attributive plural in

1 Kgs 16:15-16 . . . וישמע העם התנים . . .
 The people were camping against Gibbethon . . . and the people
 camping (pl.) heard (s.) . . .

The initial plural predicate “were camping” presumably highlights the contrast between the relative positions of the king—in the capital—and the people (i.e., the army)—on campaign. The army is thus not under the king’s control, and so is able to set up its commander as a rival to him. The continued use of the plural in the attributive “camping” may simply be due to attraction, but it may be intended to highlight the significance of this group of people for the event described. The use of a singular verb no doubt reflects the fact that the clause is relatively low in transitivity, and presents an event which is effectively background to the more significant crowning of the king described in the next clause (see §7.3). The situation is similar in 2 Sam 19:4, where the plural attributive הנכלמים heightens the simile likening David’s victorious troops to “people disgraced by defeat,” carrying on the theme of “victory turned to defeat” begun in 2 Sam 19:3. The singular verb יתגנב “steals away” reflects the fact that the clause is of no significance for the ongoing narrative.

6.8 As described, then, an adjective, participle, or demonstrative attributive to a collective is typically singular. This is the “unmarked” situation. The use of the plural, which contrasts with this, generally correlates with particular significance in the narrative. That is, the “marked” use indicates narrative prominence. It is also true that adjectives and participles which denote an enduring quality or characteristic of the collective modified are almost invariably singular (as are demonstratives), while the participles of active verbs in other uses are more frequently plural. That is, the correlation of singular with stative/passive/reflexive value and plural with action noted in §2.2 is evident here. This shows that the level of transitivity was a significant factor in the choice of number in attributives. This could be considered as a separate factor, or as an aspect of what is called here “narrative prominence,” a question discussed in §9.2. The information given in §§6.6, 6.7, shows that the factors which determine the choice of number in an attributive are independent of those which determine the choice of number in a verb. This conclusion is confirmed in §8.2.

7. Other Coreferents of Collective Subjects

7.1 This section surveys the choice of number in pronouns, other than that in the verb, which are coreferent with a collective subject. The term “verb” is used in this section with the meaning “head of the predicate.” The few cases where a collective subject is marked for number by a participle or other nominal acting as head of the predicate are included. The general rule is that, when the collective is marked as plural, following coreferents are typically also plural. Where the collective is marked as singular, coreferents in the same clause (or in clauses subordinate to it) are usually singular. Otherwise they are plural. Coreferent pronouns in other following clauses are typically plural. Usage contrasting with these “unmarked” situations appears to carry a semantic load.

The collective is marked as plural.

7.2 Where a collective is subject of a plural verb, a coreferent is typically plural. In most of the exceptions noted, the singular coreferent can be understood as distributive in value; there is ellipsis of **איש** ‘man/each’ which is typically used in the distributive structure,³² as

Judg 2:10	וגם כל הדור ההוא נאספו אל אבותיו
All that generation was gathered (pl.) {each} to his fathers.	

The same occurs in Judg 20:33 “All the men of Israel rose (pl.) {each} from his place” (**ממקומו**); also probably in the subordinate clause in 1 Sam 13:6 “The men of Israel saw (pl.) {each} that he was in distress” (**כי צר לו**); and possibly in the descriptive clause in Judg 20:17 “The men of Israel gathered (pl.) . . . ; {each one} of these (**כל זה**) was a warrior.” Further examples of pronouns which may have distributive value are given in §8.4. In Judg 1:34, **לא נתנו** “he did not allow him,” the subject, “he,” is coreferent with a collective subject treated as plural, the object, “him,” with a plural nominal. It seems likely that the text has been disturbed.

³²See J. Levi, *Die Inkongruenz im biblischen Hebräisch* (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1987): 34, D.

The collective is marked as singular.

7.3 Where a collective is subject of a singular verb, a coreferent pronoun in the same clause, or in a clause subordinate to it, is usually singular.³³ In such cases, the clause is typically low in narrative prominence and transitivity, as

2 Sam 10:15 וירא ארם כי נגף לפני ישראל
Aram saw (s.) that it was driven back before Israel.

Here the subordinate clause presents the motivation for a new mobilization of the forces of Aram. It is introductory to a description of the activities of their leader, which are of interest only as indicating David's problems. Thus the clause is low in narrative prominence. In addition, the clause is intransitive. A plural coreferent is used in situations high in narrative prominence or transitivity, as

1 Kgs 12:16 וירא כל ישראל כי לא שמע המלך אליהם
All Israel saw (s.) that the king did not listen to *them*.

Here the clause is also introductory, but it presents the immediate cause of the division of the kingdom, and so is central to the narrator's concerns, and high in narrative prominence. The clause is negative, but transitive. The plural is also used in Judg 2:10 (ידעו), presenting a defect in the people which is crucial to the narrative), Judg 7:2 (בירם), in a clause which presents the motivation for the reduction in the strength of Gideon's force), Judg 20:39 (אמר), presenting the thought which determines Benjamin's disastrous action), 2 Sam 19:4 (בנוסם), highlighting the theme of victory turned to defeat, as the preceding נכלמים, see §6.7), and 2 Kgs 17:19 (אלהיהם), where the plural highlights the fact that the essential obedience to God was abandoned). The final case, בעלותם (Judg 11:16), is difficult to evaluate, as it is the only example of a pronoun of this sort preceding the collective and its verb. The use of the plural is possibly anomalous (cf. the singular suffix on the infinitive used in the same context, but following the verb, in Judg 11:13).

³³Judg 1:3,17,32; 11:13; 18:1; 20:33,40,41 (עליו, ראה); 1 Sam 14:30 (איביו, מצא); 15:2 (שם, לו, בעלותו); 2 Sam 10:15; 1 Kgs 12:16 (לאהליו); 2 Kgs 17:18; 25:21. It is noteworthy that the proportion of cases occurring in passages of historical synopsis (Judges 1, 11:13–21, and 20, see §9.4)—eight singular to two plural—is considerably higher than the proportion occurring elsewhere—ten singular to five plural.

7.4 This description can be tested against contrasting usage, as in

1 Kgs 8:44 כי יצא עמך למלחמה על איבו בדרך אשר תשלחם
When your people goes out to war against its enemy in the way in
which you will send them . . .

The singular is used in “its enemy,” which contributes little (“war” implies an enemy). The plural is used in “you will send them,” which makes the crucial stipulation that the people acts under God’s direction. This can be compared with “the spoil of its enemies which it found” (1 Sam 14:30). The pronouns refer to “the people.” The clause of which this is subject is somewhat obscure, but is clearly introductory to what follows, and so low in narrative prominence, and also *irrealis* (“past untrue”), and so low in transitivity.³⁴

7.5 Where a collective subject of a singular verb has coreferents acting as subject of following coordinate clauses, the coreferents are usually plural (24 cases in all), as

Judg 1:30 וישב הכנעני בקרבו ויהיו למס
The Canaanite lived (s.) in his territory and became (pl.) forced
labour.

2 Kgs 7:16 ויצא העם ויבזו את מחנה ארם
The people came out (s.) and plundered (pl.) the camp of Aram.

The initial clause is typically introductory (as in these examples) and so low in narrative prominence. It is often lower in transitivity than the following clause (as in 2 Kgs 7:16). This is the standard or “unmarked” usage, however, so it may not be a direct reflection of these features. The contrasting use of the singular occurs where two or more closely related verbs are used in introduction, in

Judg 12:1 ויצעק איש אפרים ויעבר צפונה ויאמרו . . .
The men of Ephraim assembled (s.) and travelled (s.) northwards
and said (pl.) . . .

Three singular verbs form an introductory unit of this sort at the start of Judg 11:18. Sets of singular predicates, with no following coreferent plural, occur in passages remarkable for their high proportion of collectives treated as singular (Judg 1:28,33; 11:16,17; 20:16,37). The only

³⁴See Hopper and Thompson (N 8): 252 (G).

other example occurs in 2 Kgs 19:30, probably because such usage is also typical of the “prophetic” register (see §9.4).

7.6 In a few cases, a non-subjective pronoun is coreferent with the collective subject of a preceding clause. The pronoun is plural in Judg 1:4; 9:43; 21:14; singular in Judg 1:2,3,29,30; 9:38; 20:41; 1 Sam 15:2; and 1 Kgs 20:13. Most examples of the singular occur in passages in which collectives are usually treated as singular (see §9.4; that in 1 Kgs 20:13 is a prophecy), so the fact that singular is more common is probably not significant. Singular and plural contrast in

Judg 1:2 יהודה יעלה הנה נתתי את הארץ בידו
Judah will go first. I have given the land into his hand.

Judg 1:4 ויעל יהודה ויתן יהוה את הכנעני והפריזי
Judah went up (s.), and the Lord gave the Canaanite and the
Perizzite into their hand.

In Judg 1:2, the clause containing the singular “his hand” is a promise made to support the preceding clause, which, as the answer to a question, has high prominence. In Judg 1:4, the use of the plural “their hand” highlights the fulfillment of this promise; the preceding clause is introductory. It is possible, then, that the plural is a mark of narrative prominence in this situation also, but the evidence is too limited for certainty. Both numbers are used in Judg 6:3–4, where the text is commonly felt to be at fault, and in Judg 20:44–45, where the plural subject may possibly reflect the tendency to treat “actors” as plural, noted in §2.2, while the singular object is characteristic of the tendency to use singular coreferents for collectives in this chapter.

8. Coreferents of Collectives which Do Not Act as Subject.

8.1 A pronoun coreferent with a collective which does not act as subject is usually plural, even where the collective is modified by a singular attributive. Singular pronouns are common only within the same clause as the collective. They usually occur as part of the same phrase³⁵ as the collective, as

³⁵The term “constituent” cannot be used unless it is defined so as to exclude relative clauses modifying a nominal. Coreferents in such clauses are typically plural, as in 1 Sam 8:7; 1 Kgs 12:9,10; and 2 Kgs 21:8 (14 cases in all). Singular coreferents occur in Judg 20:10; 21:12; 1 Kgs 3:8; and 22:47. See §8.5.

2 Kgs 2:12; 13:14

רכב ישראל ופרשיו

The chariotry of Israel and its horsemen.

See also 2 Sam 2:9 (כלה) and 1 Kgs 12:20 (לבדו). A singular pronoun is used in another constituent in 1 Sam 15:2 (עליו, לו) and 2 Kgs 24:2 (להאבדו) where the context is a historical synopsis (see §9.4). A pronoun in a constituent other than that containing the collective is usually plural, as in Judg 20:10 (לבואם), 20:38 (להעלתם), 2 Sam 2:26 (אחיהם), 3:18 (איביהם), 1 Kgs 12:27 (אדניהם), 16:2 (בחטאתם), 16:26 (בהבליהם), and 22:11 (כלתם). A plural coreferent occurs in the same constituent as the collective only in

2 Kgs 16:15

... עלת כל עם הארץ ומנחתם ונסכיהם ...

The whole offering of all the people of the land, and their meal offering and their drink offering.

8.2 The difference between the example in 2 Kgs 16:15 and that in 2 Kgs 2:12 might well be that in 2 Kgs 2:12 the pronoun merely represents the possessor. In 2 Kgs 6:15 it represents the performer of an action, a situation conducive to the use of the plural (see §2.2). Apart from this possibility, the choice of number in this situation appears to be conditioned mainly by the “syntactic domain” of the collective. Where the collective acts as subject, the syntactic domain which governs the choice of number is typically the whole clause, including subordinate clauses (see §7.3). In the situation discussed here, where the collective is not marked for number by the head of the predicate, this syntactic domain is usually limited to the phrase in which the collective occurs, even where it is marked for number by an attributive, as in 1 Kgs 12:27. This confirms the conclusion reached in §6.8, that the factors which condition number in the attributive of a collective and those which condition the choice in the verb of which it is subject, are independent. That is, as argued here, a collective is not categorized in isolation as grammatically singular or plural. The choice of number is conditioned by the situation in which the collective is used.

8.3 The special situation of an addressee designated by a collective in an introduction to a speech conforms to the above description in that plural coreferent pronouns are typically used within the speech, as in 1 Sam 7:3, 11:9, 12:1, and 14:40. The singular is used in Judg 1:3, in a passage showing a tendency to use the singular (see §9.4). The use of the singular in *לְאֵהֱלִיךְ יִשְׂרָאֵל* (1 Kgs 12:16) “To your (s.) tents, Israel!” may possibly derive (by ellipsis or error) from the typical distributive

structure “Each to your (s.) tents . . .” (. . . איש לאהליך cf. 2 Chron 10:16; 1 Kgs 22:36).³⁶

8.4 The plural is typically used in other cases in which the coreferent pronoun does not stand in the same clause as the collective. This includes 26 cases where the pronoun stands in a relative or other subordinate clause, and some 70 in which it stands in a main clause. Examples are

Judg 8:5 תנו ... לעם ... כי עיפים הם
Give ... to the people ... because they are weary.

Judg 9:43 ויקח את העם ויחצם . . .
He took the people and divided them . . .

1 Sam 8:7 שמע בקול העם לכל אשר יאמרו . . .
Listen to the people, to all that they say . . .

1 Kgs 8:66 שלח את העם ויברכו . . .
He dismissed the people, and they blessed . . .

8.5 Singular pronouns occur sporadically. In some cases, the singular may have distributive value (cf. 1 Kgs 8:38). In Judg 20:16 כל זה may mean “each one of these,” describing an active force as opposed to כל אלה (Judg 20:25,35) “all of these,” describing the dead (cf. Judg 20:17 in §7.2). Judg 21:12 (אשר לא ידעה) “400 girls, none of whom had known a man”), Judg 7:4 (. . . ואצרפנו . . . ורד אותם) “Take them (the people) down . . . and I will test each . . .”), and 1 Kgs 5:28 (בביתו “each to his house”)³⁷ could similarly be interpreted as distributive. A few other examples occur in the passages marked by a tendency to treat collectives as singular (Judg 1:28; 11:23; 20:10,39,43). The collective “Israel” similarly has singular coreferents in the passage of prophecy in 2 Sam 7:10 (see §9.4). The other cases I have noted are Judg 6:35 (“Menasseh also was called out [s.]”), Judg 7:9 (“I have given it [the camp] into your power”), 1 Sam 15:3 (“Attack Amalek and destroy all that is his, and do not pity him”), 1 Sam 15:6 (“Depart from among the Amalekite lest I remove you with him”), 1 Sam 15:18 (“Destroy . . .

³⁶Shifts in number occasionally occur in first and second person pronouns, as in Judg 11:19, 1 Sam 15:3, 30:22, 2 Sam 19:43. Such shifts appear to be features of the use of these pronouns, not of the use of collectives, and so are not considered here. The shift from plural to singular pronouns coreferent with the collective addressee in 1 Sam 15:6 is one of these.

³⁷The antecedent **וְאֵל** in verse 27 is complement of a singular verb, but the intervening coreferents are plural.

Amalek, and fight him until you [!] destroy them”), 1 Kgs 3:8 (“A large people which cannot be numbered nor counted . . .”), 1 Kgs 22:47 (“The rest of the sacred prostitutes which is left . . .”). Several of these cases show low narrative prominence or transitivity. Nevertheless, the situations generally are not clearly distinct from those in which plural pronouns are used, so these cases must be regarded as anomalous.

9. Conclusion.

9.1 This survey shows that, generally speaking, the choice of number in coreferents of the collectives in the corpus follows regular patterns. Where the collective is subject of a clause, the head of the predicate is generally singular, as are other coreferents within the clause, and in clauses subordinate to it. More distant coreferents, outside the syntactic unit formed by the clause, are generally plural.³⁸ Where a collective does not act as subject, coreferents are also usually plural; the singular is common only within the same constituent as the collective. A nominal attributive to a collective is generally singular, but this also has no effect on other relationships within the clause. Where singular is expected, the use of the plural is mainly determined by the prominence of the collective or its clause in the narrative. Other factors, particularly high transitivity, and the fact that the collective is actor, are also conducive to the use of the plural. Certain passages, characterized above as “historical synopsis” or “prophetic register,” use an unusually high proportion of singular coreferents. Outside these passages, the proportion of examples which must be described as anomalies, in that they clearly conflict with the common pattern, is negligible.

9.2 “Narrative prominence” is a form of “grounding,” and so related to the level of transitivity (see §3.4). The two factors which mainly determine the use of the plural can, then, be seen as aspects of a single factor, for which the term “immediacy” seems appropriate. Material which is prominent in the narrative is “immediate” in the sense that it is central to the narrator’s purpose. Narrative is concerned with a series of

³⁸Other languages also show a shift from “unnatural” to “natural” concord as the distance between a pronoun and its antecedent widens. See Mühlhäusler and Harré ([N 6]: 72), also the Shakespearean examples noted in Fries ([N 6]: 21). The same phenomenon is shown in Nixon ([N 6]: 125). (Cf. the examples on p. 123. The exception for S-V concord noted on p. 125 probably reflects the failure to take clause boundaries into consideration. S-V concord is limited to the clause in which the collective stands, or one subordinate to it. Pronominal concord is not.)

events—with action. Consequently, clauses which present activity are more likely to be significant for the narrative than clauses which do not. This is no doubt the basis for the correlation between function as subject—as “actor”—and the use of the plural noted in §2.2. This phenomenon was associated with transitivity in §2 and §3, but it seems quite probable that the level of transitivity is, in this context, simply a measure of the degree of “action” significant to the narrative.

9.3 The use of concord to mark structure as prominent or significant in the narrative has a parallel in direct speech, where concord in person is one of several features used to mark significance in terms of the purpose or concerns of the speaker. Where deference is required, deferential nominals or other third person forms are used to refer to speaker and addressee. First or second person pronouns express “immediacy”; their use reflects the strong concern or emotion of the speaker.³⁹ Concord with collectives is, then, part of a network of features used throughout the language to show that a structure is “immediate”—particularly significant in its context, or “non-immediate”—distanced, background, and relatively unimportant.

9.4 Thus the choice of singular in a verb with a collective subject does correspond to the common conventions of grammar, but this “unmarked” or “default” form is used because the situation does not require the use of the plural to mark immediacy. The use of the plural may show that the referent of the collective is viewed as a number of individuals, but its use is determined by the need to mark the immediacy of the structure. The increased use of the singular in passages of historical synopsis is consistent with this. The narrative in Judges chapters 1, 11:13–21, and 20, is mainly concerned with political actions. No leaders or rulers are named (save in the Caleb story in Judg 1:12–15 = Josh 15:16–19); the actions are viewed abstractly, as undertaken by population groups seen as “states.” In more vivid narrative passages, such political actions are typically depicted as performed by the leader of the group treated as an individual, whether named alone, as in 2 Sam 8:1, or as head of a compound treated as singular, as in 1 Sam 23:5. In the three passages of historical synopsis, the narrator presents the political struggles as background to the narrative of those aspects of the history of Israel

³⁹The expression of immediacy in deferential speech, and some related usage, has been explored at length in E. J. Revell, *The Designation of the Individual: Expressive Usages in Biblical Narrative* (CBET 14; Kampen: Kok Pharos, 1996). For examples of the speaker’s concerns influencing the choice of number in a collective, see 1 Kgs 2:15 (§4.8), and Judg 9:37 (§6.4).

which are his major interest. The predominant designation of population groups as singular (which is not confined to the coreferents of collectives, see §2.5) is one of the marks of this intention.⁴⁰ Occasional structures are marked by the plural as immediate, but the preponderant choice is the singular, marking the passage as less important, as background. The tendency to use the singular in passages of prophecy (see 2 Kgs 19:30 in §§6.6, 7.5; 1 Kgs 20:13 in §7.6; 2 Sam 7:10 in §8.5) can be seen as the counterpart of this. Just as statements about the future are low in transitivity⁴¹ they are also low in immediacy.

9.5 By the end of the biblical period, collectives were most commonly treated as plural.⁴² Nevertheless, conditioning similar to that outlined above appears still to have operated. In column 58 of the Temple Scroll,⁴³ collectives are treated as singular in primary relationship in six of seven cases. A predicate with a collective subject is singular in a conditional clause (*irrealis*, low in transitivity; see Hopper and Thompson⁴⁴), in 58:6 (בא "arrive"), 58:16 (יצא "leave"); plural in 58:11 (יכרתו "be cut off"), where the verb is both passive and negated, but presents an important prescription. An attributive is singular in 58:6,7 (רב), consistent with §6.1. The attributive מִבְּקֶשׁ (58.3) is probably singular because it stands in a conditional clause (*irrealis*), but might be considered as presenting a temporary characteristic (see §6.1). More remote coreferents are plural in 58:6,17. The text itself presents a prescription for political activity in the ideal future. The other cases of singular collectives quoted by E. Qimron⁴⁵ occur in similar "non-immediate" situations.⁴⁶ It appears, then, that the general basis for the choice of a singular or plural coreferent for a collective did not change, although the area in which the use of the plural was felt to be appropriate was expanded. This expansion quite possibly resulted from the desire for more striking forms of expression. The use of the "marked form," the plural, expressing "immedi-

⁴⁰Possibly the narrator retained usage original in his sources, but the material from the Temple Scroll discussed in §9.5 suggests that there is no reason why he should not have been responsible for the predominant use of the singular in these passages.

⁴¹See Hopper and Thompson (N 8): 252 (C, D, G).

⁴²Qimron (N 4): §400.18.

⁴³Y. Yadin, *Megillat ha-Miqdash* (Jerusalem: Israel Exploration Society et al., 1977); *The Temple Scroll* (Jerusalem: Israel Exploration Society et al., 1983).

⁴⁴Hopper and Thompson (N 8): 252 (G).

⁴⁵Qimron (N 4): 83 n. 64.

⁴⁶4Q160 3 III:2, 6. The same is true for 1Q27 1 I:10-11, which Qimron (N 4) quotes, where עַם and גִּי would be regarded as collectives in this paper. In the terms used here, both texts use the "prophetic register." See §9.4.

acy," was increased until it became the common "unmarked" form, and speakers had to develop new means of making their language more vivid.⁴⁷

9.6 The language of Qumran represents a late stage in the development of the tendency to treat collectives as plural. The usage of the corpus, where collectives are treated as singular in their primary syntactic relationships in 60% of the cases, represents an earlier stage. Presumably, in yet earlier stages, the singular was even more frequently used. It is possible that successive generations of the ancients viewed the increasing use of the plural as progressive abandonment of "classical" grammar for "vulgar" usage, as was the tendency among more recent grammarians. From another point of view, however, it represents the increasing exploitation of a development which made use of spare morphosyntactic capacity. In other words it is an example of one of the ways in which the expressive capabilities of languages are developed.

⁴⁷ Desire for a striking expression may also have caused the drift from V-S-O to S-V-O order in clauses. See T. Givón, "The Drift from VSO to SVO in Biblical Hebrew: The Pragmatics of Tense-Aspect," in *Mechanisms of Syntactic Change* (ed. Charles N. Li; Austin: Univ. of Texas, 1977): #9. Similar motivation (the desire not to use language with undesirable connotations) may account for the general replacement of the singular second person pronoun by the plural in English (K. M. Wales, "Thou and You in Early Modern English: Brown and Gilman Reappraised," *Studia Linguistica* 37 [1983]: 107-125).